

6. It's all in the details

The smaller details often reveal the bigger picture and point to the overall quality of the development. Richards' dead giveaways? 'I would be looking closely at the joinery details and how materials come together,' he says. Look for large gaps in the joinery that don't look like they need to be there; lots of bog and silicon used to fill up gaps; cupboard panels that aren't flush; and lighting used as an afterthought (avoid 'a sea of recessed downlights [and instead, look for] a few different settings, to have the apartment lit beautifully at night in a couple of different ways'). Also, ensure the appliances and tapware in the kitchen and bathroom are reputable brands.

7. Room sizes

Will the apartment serve you for the next phase of life, if that includes children? Richards says:

I have raised a family in apartments. People tend to say, 'You'll be living in an inner-city location and need to move out and buy a house somewhere,' but families in Manhattan, Tokyo and Paris are able to raise their families in apartments – it is something we are not used to in Australia and we will have to become used to it. In many ways, there is a greater sense of community in an apartment building than there is in the streets of the suburbs. I have lots of friends who live in the suburbs who don't know their neighbours, but living in apartments, I have wonderful friends who live in the building and neighbouring buildings.

7. A house-and-land package

Must have: A realistic timeframe for infrastructure, such as schools, transport and shopping, to be drip-fed into the new estate, making living in this developing area easy and enjoyable.

Why? The most affordable way to buy a house that fits your criteria with fewer size and design compromises, and five-figure national grants for first home buyers who build or buy new.